

COLLECTION · LIFE SITUATIONS

Retirement, Real Estate and Downsizing

Downsize, free up cash and make real estate work for retirement

READ BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Important notice

This guide is provided for informational and educational purposes only. It offers general information about real estate in Quebec and does not constitute personalized real estate, legal, tax or financial advice. As every real estate situation is different, it is recommended that you consult the appropriate professionals before making any decision regarding a real estate transaction.

© 2026 Émilie Cauvier — La Bibliothèque. All rights reserved. Any reproduction, distribution, sharing or resale, in whole or in part, by any means whatsoever, is strictly prohibited without prior written authorization. This guide is intended for the personal use of the purchaser.

Retirement, Real Estate and Downsizing · Collection Life situations · Guide No. 46 · 2026
Edition

Retirement, Real Estate and Downsizing

Downsize, free up cash and make real estate work for retirement

As you approach or live in retirement, your property often becomes your main asset — and a lever for quality of life. Downsizing, freeing up cash or generating income: several options are open to you.

This guide explores real estate strategies in retirement, with their advantages and their points of vigilance.

Informational content, not financial advice: consult your advisors. Each chapter ends with a lined “My notes” page.

As you approach or live in retirement, your property often becomes your main asset — and a lever for quality of life. This guide explores downsizing, ways to generate income, transfer, and adapting the home to age in place.

Informational content, not financial advice: consult the relevant professionals.

CHAPTER

Downsizing: reduce to live better

Weighing the value of reducing size.

Selling a large house for a smaller property (condo, smaller house) can transform your daily life.

- Less maintenance, taxes and energy costs.
- Potential cash freed up by the price difference.
- A simplified life, often better suited.

It's often a **quality-of-life** choice as much as a financial one. Still to assess: transaction and moving costs, and attachment to the house.

Selling a large house for a smaller one (condo, reduced house) eases maintenance, taxes and energy, frees up cash and simplifies life. It's often a quality-of-life choice as much as a financial one; weigh the transaction costs and the attachment to the house.

EMILIE'S TIP

Downsizing isn't only about money. Many retirees tell me they mostly gained time and peace. Weigh the comfort of living as much as the financial calculation.

CHAPTER

Generating income or freeing up cash

Putting your real estate wealth to work.

Your property can become an income lever in retirement:

- **Downsizing + investment:** invest the difference for income.
- **Income property:** generate rents (with the management that implies).
- **Tapping the equity** of the residence (some loans suited to seniors): to examine cautiously.

Each option has tax and risk implications: the goal is *sustainable* income, not a gamble.

Your property can become an income lever: downsizing + investing the difference, an income property (with the management that implies), or equity-tapping solutions (to examine cautiously). Each option has tax and risk implications: aim for sustainable income, not a gamble.

EMILIE'S TIP

Be wary of “miracle” solutions to turn your house into cash. Some cost a lot in interest over the long term. Always have them validated by an independent advisor.

CHAPTER

Thinking transfer and long term

Integrating real estate into your estate planning.

Your property is part of the **estate** you'll pass on. Thinking about it early avoids many complications for your loved ones:

- **Will** kept up to date.
- **Taxation** of the estate.
- **Fairness** among heirs.

Coordinate your real estate decisions with your overall financial and estate planning, ideally with a notary and a planner.

Your property is part of the estate to pass on: thinking early about the transfer (will, estate taxation, fairness among heirs) avoids complications for your loved ones. Talk about it during your lifetime: a house to be shared among several children is a classic source of conflict.

EMILIE'S TIP

Talk about your intentions to your loved ones during your lifetime. A house that must be shared among several children is a classic source of conflict — one that clarity easily prevents.

CHAPTER

Staying home: adapting the property

Aging at home safely.

Not everyone wants to move. Staying in your property can be an excellent choice, provided you **adapt** it:

- Reduce the **obstacles** (steps, thresholds, bathtub).
- Improve **lighting** and **safety** (grab bars, non-slip).
- Plan for **maintenance** handed to services if needed.

Anticipating these adaptations means calmly extending the pleasure of living at home.

Staying home can be an excellent choice, provided you adapt the property: reduce obstacles (steps, thresholds, bathtub), improve lighting and safety, plan for delegated maintenance. These adaptations cost little and change everything for aging at home safely.

EMILIE'S TIP

Small safety adaptations cost little and change everything for aging at home. Think of them before you need them: an adapted bathroom beats an avoidable fall.

CHAPTER

Building your retirement real estate strategy

Deciding according to your quality of life and safety.

There's no single solution: the right strategy is the one that matches YOUR situation. A simple approach:

1. **Clarify** your needs (space, costs, income, autonomy).
2. **Estimate** the net worth of your property.
3. **Compare** the options (downsizing, income, staying home).
4. **Coordinate** with your financial and estate plan.

Decide with professional guidance, but always according to your life priorities.

There's no single solution: the right strategy matches YOUR situation. Start with “how do I want to live my retirement?”, then let the real estate follow. Estimate your net worth, compare the options and coordinate with your financial and estate plan.

EMILIE'S TIP

Start with the question “how do I want to live my retirement?”, then let the real estate follow. The house is a means serving your life project, not the other way around.

IN PRACTICE

Action plan

Your next steps, concretely.

This week

1. Clarify my retirement needs (space, costs, income).
2. Estimate the net worth of my property.

Within 30 days

1. Explore downsizing and income options with an advisor.
2. Review my estate planning with a notary.

Next

1. Decide on a strategy aligned with my quality of life and safety.

For my strategy

1. Clarify my retirement needs and estimate the net worth of my property.
2. Compare downsizing, income and staying home with an advisor.

REFERENCES

Resources & glossary

- Downsizing: moving to a smaller, less costly property.
 - Equity: the net worth of the property, to be tapped cautiously.
 - Retirement income: what an investment or a rental can support.
 - Estate planning: integrating real estate into the will.
 - Independent advisor: a neutral professional to assess the options.
-
- Downsizing: moving to a smaller, less costly property.
 - Equity: the net worth of the property, to be tapped cautiously.
 - Estate planning: integrating real estate into the will.
 - Aging in place: adapting the home to grow old there.
 - Independent advisor: a neutral professional to assess the options.

GOING FURTHER

Quiz — test your knowledge

1. Downsizing consists of:

- A) Enlarging your house
- B) Moving to a smaller, less costly property
- C) Buying a building
- D) Renting a cottage

2. Downsizing can bring:

- A) More maintenance
- B) Lower costs and some cash
- C) More taxes
- D) No change

3. An income property generates:

- A) No income
- B) Rents, with the management that implies
- C) Taxes only
- D) Insurance

4. Equity-tapping solutions must be:

- A) Signed without thinking
- B) Examined cautiously and with advice
- C) Always avoided
- D) Free

5. The property is part of:

- A) No estate
- B) The estate to pass on
- C) Taxes only
- D) Insurance

6. To avoid inheritance conflicts, you must:

- A) Say nothing
- B) Clarify your intentions (will, discussion)
- C) Sell everything in secret
- D) Wait

7. Staying home often requires you to:

- A) Change nothing
- B) Adapt the property (safety, obstacles)
- C) Move
- D) Rent

8. Safety adaptations:

- A) Cost a fortune
- B) Cost little and change a lot
- C) Are useless
- D) Are forbidden

9. The right retirement real estate strategy is:

- A) The same for everyone
- B) The one aligned with your situation and priorities
- C) Always to sell
- D) Always to keep

10. In retirement, real estate should be:

- A) The ultimate goal
- B) A means serving your life project
- C) Ignored
- D) Decided by the children

Answer key

- 1. **B** — Reducing the size (ch. 1).
- 2. **B** — Lower costs, cash (ch. 1).
- 3. **B** — Rents and management (ch. 2).
- 4. **B** — Caution and independent advice (ch. 2).
- 5. **B** — The inheritance estate (ch. 3).
- 6. **B** — Clarity and a will (ch. 3).
- 7. **B** — Adapt the home (ch. 4).
- 8. **B** — Inexpensive, very useful (ch. 4).

9. **B** — Suited to each person (ch. 5).

10. **B** — A means, not an end (ch. 5).

Signé PAR Em

*Thank you for reading. May this guide help you
decide with confidence, with all the information
in hand.*

© 2026 Émilie Cauvier — La Bibliothèque. All rights reserved. Any reproduction, distribution, sharing or resale, in whole or in part, by any means whatsoever, is strictly prohibited without prior written authorization.
This guide is intended for the personal use of the purchaser.